

Mgt 439 – Topics in Organizational Behavior: Strategic Communications – Spring 2026

4 Units, MBA-PT

Class Meetings: Mondays, 6:30pm-9:20pm

Location: OTRSN 3E107

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Office Hours: Mondays 9:20-10:50pm and by appointment

Course Description:

In today's lightning-fast global business environment, the ability to communicate strategically—in person and virtually, in a team meeting, boardroom, public forum or a venture capital pitch—is essential for impactful leadership. This highly participatory course equips current and aspiring managers with skills and techniques to deliver strategic communications that inspire trust, build relationships, influence decisions, and drive action.

Managers are called upon to rally teams, secure resources, pitch ideas, respond to challenges and influence stakeholders. Whether you're addressing a single individual or a large group your ability to present with clarity, confidence, and authenticity can determine success. The ability to strategically communicate and invite sustained relationships and collaboration through communications are invaluable capabilities of effective managers.

This course explores not only the external techniques of high-impact presentations—eye contact, vocal projection, gesturing—but also the deeper, transformational skills that distinguish great communicators. You'll learn to speak from both the mind and heart to directly influence the minds and hearts of others. You'll develop confidence in utilizing emotional intelligence and articulating your unique point of view. Innovative techniques drawn from both theater and leadership training will help you connect with audiences in ways that are strategic, memorable and motivating.

Through a combination of lecture, demonstration, creative exercises, improvisations, peer feedback, and individual coaching you will develop and refine your communications for a wide range of business contexts, including:

- Attracting top talent to your teams
- Gaining stakeholder buy-in for key initiatives
- Articulating technical content to broad constituencies
- Motivating teams to embrace new goals or challenges

- Pitching prospective clients for products or services
- Securing interest from investors and/or funders
- Navigating informal conversations or networking events

Each session will involve development, rehearsal, and performance of key messages using proven templates and coaching techniques. You'll leave this course more confident, creative, and compelling—ready to lead through standing-ovation level strategic communications.

INSTRUCTIONAL METHODS

Each class will include lecture/demonstration and “rehearsal” of key skills and techniques. The class is highly participatory. Students will follow script templates and create impactful presentations. Each class will include developing, rehearsing, and presenting key communications. Instructor and classmates will provide coaching and feedback.

OBJECTIVES

At the close of Strategic Communications you will gain:

- Increased comfort and confidence in multiple platforms for presenting
- Techniques to draw in, engage, and move audiences to action
- Confidence being spontaneous and “in the moment” and adjusting to the emotional states and diverse backgrounds of others
- Experience drawing on authentic interests, passions, and real-life experiences as the basis for strategic communications
- Practice in key skills including eye contact, gestures, vocal projection, use of imagery
- Knowledge of templates, techniques and structures for more succinct and articulate presentations
- Experience in “fierce conversations”
- Strategies for effective visual materials
- A working vocabulary to observe and discuss the presentations of others

READING MATERIALS

- ***Leading Out Loud: Inspiring Change Through Authentic Communication*** by Terry Pearce – Chapters 1, 2, and 3
- ***Storytelling with Data: a data visualization guide for business professionals*** by Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic – Chapters 1, 2, and 7
- ***Slide:ology: The Art and Science of Creating Great Presentations*** by Nancy Duarte – Chapters 4, 5
- ***Fierce Conversations*** by Susan Scott – Chapters 3, 7

Course Schedule:

Session	Date	Topic	Reading/Viewing	Deliverables
1	3-30	Your Point of View and Value You Bring A management communication should reflect our point of view and what we most value. Effective management communications draw upon an individual's unique experiences and insight. Even your data presentation is strengthened by your connection to the topic. Identifying your communications "sweet spot," and personal foundations of advocacy to draw others to your message.	Leading Out Loud Chapter 1 – Discovering What Matters p. 9-22	Presentation #1 – story reflecting values developed and coached in-class.
2	4-6	Improvisation, Authenticity & Storytelling Great communicators feel spontaneous and authentic shaping their delivery "in the moment" to audiences. Presenters must effectively improvise when they: field questions, converse with panels, adjust to unexpected circumstances, and reshape and rework material for specific audiences. When networking, you must listen, think on your feet, ask questions, express what you are doing, and connect. You will learn basic techniques in theatre improvisation and then practice opportunities to use these skills to plunge "off the page" in management presentations and conversations.	Storytelling with Data Chapter 1 – The importance of Context p. 19-33 Chapter 7 – Lessons in Storytelling p. 165-185	Presentation #2 - an authentic story from 3 options using story structure developed in-class
3	4-13	Storytelling With Data You have access to more data than ever but how are you going to communicate it in a clear, persuasive and articulate way to diverse stakeholders? Your data will enable you to make invaluable recommendations if you can articulate an effective "data story." You will learn and rehearse techniques getting individuals, teams, boards, and companies to "buy in" to compelling stories of your data.	Storytelling with Data Chapter 2 – Choosing an effective visual p. 35-69	Presentation #3 - First two minutes of a presentation to invite buy-in. Includes "winning the first 60 seconds," sharing authenticity and facts.
4	4-20	Effective Graphic Design & Structure A great presentation paints a vivid picture of a desired future. When Dr. Martin Luther King spoke, "I have a dream..." he did not just talk about the evils of racism, he brilliantly painted a dream of the future in vivid imagery. How can you paint when your only visual information is a slide graph or a bar chart over-stuffed with text? The most memorable and engaging moments are often imagery and metaphors. You will	Slide:ology Chapter 4 – Displaying Data p 63-77 Chapter 5 – Thinking like a designer p. 81-89	Presentation #3 - First two minutes of a presentation to invite buy-in. Includes "winning the first 60 seconds," sharing

		learn to design clear, captivating, moving, and vivid images in language and slides that animate your ideas, create empathy and inspire a desired outcome.		authenticity and facts.
5	4-27	Vocal/Physical Presence & Winning the First 60 Seconds In theatre, actors' auditions are won or lost in the first 60 seconds. Management presentations are often the same! Your audience makes decisions about You, your Content, Data, Message, and Competence the MOMENT you begin. Your confidence, tone of voice, choice of words, body language and gestures all convey key information and propel audiences to engage or not. In this session, you will develop and rehearse the opening of an upcoming presentation. We will explore opening structures and techniques to invite your audience to connect with your material and you. Standing Ovation presentations begin by Winning the First 60 Seconds.	Leading Out Loud Chapter 3 – Connecting with Others p. 46-66	In Class you will develop: Presentation #4 - Opening a data-driven communication that expresses the value you bring, and your personal commitment to an objective.
6	5-4	Emotional Intelligence Without being able to observe and understand our own and our audience's emotions we cannot have maximum impact. In the theatre we use words, movement and images to constantly shape emotions. How do your emotions affect others? Can you read facial expressions and body language to "take the emotional temperature" of a meeting or conversation and adjust to the states of others. Rehearsing how presentations incorporate and adapt to your own and others' emotions.	Leading Out Loud Chapter 2 – Deepening Emotional Awareness p. 23 – 33	Re-draft the content for Presentation #4 - incorporating techniques from "emotional intelligence."
7	5-11	Fierce Conversations, and the Speed of Trust Managers must frequently facilitate difficult and/or uncomfortable communications. Breakdowns must be discussed, performances evaluated, partnerships examined and realigned. Following the "Fierce Conversations" model, how to "examine reality" and create a shared commitment to a change/new result WITHOUT all the drama.	Fierce Conversations Chapter 3 – Be Here Prepared to Go Nowhere Else p. 110-145	In Class you will develop Presentation #5 - Fierce Conversation
8	5-18	Vision Discovering, expressing, and getting others to commit to your vision of a future possibility. What are practical applications of 10,000ft, 20,000ft, and 30,000ft views? How do you make others share your sense of stakes for a desired future?	Fierce Conversations Chapter 7 – Let Silence Do the	In Class you will develop: Presentation #6 - Advocating your vision. This will be

		Practice using “Appreciative Inquiry” to facilitate the creation of a “team” presentation.	Heavy Lifting p 274-296	done in “teams” of 4-5 people.
9		Memorial Day – No Class		
10		Final Presentation: Delivering Your Message Class devoted to Presentation #7, in depth coaching, and peer/instructor critique. Summary and discussion of most impactful applications of class concepts and opportunities for continued rehearsal and growth.		Presentation #7 (final) - Your most impactful upcoming presentation or management conversation.

ASSIGNMENTS

All class assignments are C - Collaboration with classmates is allowed. However, each student must present individual work.

Reading/Viewing Assignments

There will be weekly assignments from *Leading Out Loud*, *Storytelling with Data*, *Fierce Conversations*, *Slide:ology*, *Made to Stick*, and *The Emotionally Intelligent Manager*. There will also be video samples of excellent presentations to observe and discuss.

Quizzes/Exams

There are no quizzes or exams, but there will be weekly short presentations, plus longer midterm and final presentations.

Instructor is available for outside of class coaching on all class presentations. Please contact instructor to schedule times in office hours or times that work for your schedule.

Class Participation

It is essential for each student to use each class as an opportunity to actively develop and rehearse presentations and communications. Participants are expected to give coaching and feedback to classmates. There will be presentations in every class.

GRADING/Assignments

Presentation #1 – 10%

Presentation #2 – 10%

Presentation #3 – 15%

Presentation #4 – 10%

Presentation #5 – 10%

Presentation #6 (*Final*) – 35%

Class Participation – 20%

COURSE POLICIES

Attendance is essential. You cannot miss more than 1 class and receive a top grade. Students are expected to be supportive of classmates, willing to share authenticity, and open to taking communications risks.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at: <http://www-senate.ucsd.edu/manual/appendices/app2.htm#AP14>

The materials that you create to be used in your presentations may quote other people, managers, or sources, but the overall content must be entirely your own.

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.